

A Heresy of Blood:

The Transition from Faith to Race in Early Modern Spain

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History 600

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Introduction:

The Spanish Inquisition is often remembered as the result of a fanatically Catholic monarchy attempting to assert religious orthodoxy and eradicate heresy. This imagination has been shaped by works such as Edgar Allen Poe's *the Pit*¹ or later efforts of Protestant opponents promulgating the idea of *La Leyenda Negra* (the Black Legend) to paint the Catholics as barbaric, juxtaposed to their enlightenment.² However, these interpretations neglect to encompass the true function of the Inquisition as a political instrument and its fundamental racial dimension. A close examination of the events that preceded the formation of the Inquisition in 1478, coupled with an analysis of procedural records, reveals that the machinery of the Church was systematically exploited by the Spanish Crown. Understanding this transformation requires moving beyond this abridged narrative of a zealous Catholic Monarchy and looking at the unique circumstances that cascaded to the Inquisition, beginning with the complex sociopolitical fabric of 15th-century Spain.

For many centuries, Medieval Spain maintained a uniquely pluralist society unlike elsewhere in Christendom. While England and France had expelled their Jewish populations by the turn of the fourteenth century, the Iberian Peninsula had the “single largest Jewish community in the World,”³ alongside, “to a less extensive degree,”⁴ a Muslim (*Mudéjar*) population, remnants of the *Reconquista*. This coexistence, however, was not one of equality. Jewish communities were legally prohibited from holding office, faced physical segregation, and were technically regarded

¹ “‘The Pit and the Pendulum’ Exhibit – The Poe Museum,” accessed December 17, 2025, <https://poemuseum.org/the-pit-and-the-pendulum-exhibit/>.

² Henry Arthur Francis Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition: A Historical Revision* (Yale University Press, 1999), 379.

³ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*. 2

⁴ Mark D. Meyerson and Norman Roth, “Conversos, Inquisition, and the Expulsion of the Jews from Spain.,” *The American Historical Review* 102, no. 1 (1997): 9, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2171284>.

as property of the Crown⁵. Nevertheless, while never equal, the “Christians found themselves heavily indebted culturally and in daily life, to Muslims and Jews.”⁶ This period, labeled *Convivencia* (living-together), describes this continuous necessary interaction between these three distinct peoples from roughly the eighth century until the end of the fifteenth century.⁷

This remarkable cohabitation likely explains the notable absence of a medieval Papal Inquisition in Castile and the resistance to establish foreign Papal tribunals, viewing them as an unnecessary imposition on Spanish sovereignty. Harboring a population of about six million,⁸ Spain was divided into two distinct realms: the Kingdom of Castile and the Kingdom of Aragon, which retained separate governments, borders, and legal systems. Significantly, they also had two distinct relationships with religious persecution. Aragon hosted a Medieval Papal Inquisition to combat the Albigensian heresy associated with refugees from France⁹. In contrast, Castile—the much larger and more populous kingdom—resisted such tribunals, relying instead on local bishops and secular jurisdiction¹⁰. The establishment of the new Inquisition in 1478 was therefore not merely the revival of an old custom, but the imposition of a new political machine.

Convivencia began to fracture under the social and economic pressures of the late 14th century. The Anti-Jewish pogroms of 1391 marked the beginning of the end of tolerance, which directly resulted in the rise of a new class, the *conversos*, Jews who converted to Christianity.

⁵ Henry Charles Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain; Vol. 1*, in <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/43296/43296-h/43296-h.htm> (2013), 36.

⁶ Meyerson and Roth, “Conversos, Inquisition, and the Expulsion of the Jews from Spain.” 9.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 1.

⁹ Ibid, 51.

¹⁰ Henry Charles Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of the Middle Ages*, 1st ed. (Cambridge University Press, 2010), 184, <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511710001>.

While these “New Christians” successfully integrated into Spanish society, it was this specific group that became the obsession of the State.

While the Spanish Inquisition is often remembered as a religious crusade, in practice, it functioned primarily as a political weapon used to target the *converso* class. By usurping the institution's jurisdictional structure from the Papacy, the Catholic Monarchs effectively nationalized a Church tribunal to pursue racial and ethnic prejudices under the legal guise of defending the faith.

I: The Catalyst

The first in a string of events leading to mass conversions were the pogroms of 1391. In Castile, rising antisemitism mixed with economic and political instability¹¹ culminated in widespread violence against Jews. Over the ensuing weeks, Córdoba, Toledo, Barcelona, Saragossa, among many others, joined in the killings across both Kingdoms¹². The bloodshed was largely driven by radical preachers¹³ inciting the lower classes to riot. Although not the first instance of massacre¹⁴, it was undoubtedly the most significant indicator of a widespread hostility, spanning both realms, marking a definitive shift from theological anti-Judaism to popular, violent antisemitism.

While the human toll was devastating, the most enduring legacy was the demographic transition that followed. Many Jews were faced with a choice between risking additional violence

¹¹ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 15.

¹² Henry Charles Lea, “Ferrand Martinez and the Massacres of 1391,” *The American Historical Review* 1, no. 2 (1896): 209–19, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1833647>.

¹³ Ibid.

¹⁴ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 51.

or taking the sacrament of baptism. Although there are no definite figures, sources agree that the conversions occurred on a massive scale,¹⁵ birthing the *converso* class. Baptism spared converts from antisemitic laws, allowing sudden freedoms to own land, enter professions¹⁶, and marry into Christian families¹⁷. As Benedictus de Spinoza later observed, because the New Christians "were admitted to all the native privileges of Spaniards... they straightway became so intermingled with the Spaniards as to leave of themselves no relic or remembrance."¹⁸ This integration extended to the highest levels of nobility, the royal administration, and the Church itself¹⁹. The assimilation of the Conversos rendered traditional religious barriers obsolete, under the law of the Church, making both Old and New Christians equal.

A mix of suspicion, jealousy, and conspiracy radicalized the shift from traditional religious to racial prejudice. *Conversos* rose to the highest levels of local government and held influential positions in finance and tax collection, amassing significant wealth and power. The success of this new class, combined with doubt regarding their sincerity of faith, created intense resentment among segments of the "Old Christian" population²⁰. For those who believed the *converso* class to be Judaizers, this rise became vastly concerning, as they were being governed by heretics. Consequently, opponents conceived the doctrine of *limpieza de sangre* (purity of blood). This new idea asserted that "Jewish blood" created a "racial inferiority" and corrupted the sacraments, which

¹⁵ Meyerson and Roth, "Conversos, Inquisition, and the Expulsion of the Jews from Spain.," 372.

¹⁶ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 125.

¹⁷ Ibid. 120.

¹⁸ Benedictus de Spinoza, *The Chief Works of Benedict de Spinoza*, trans. R.H.M. Elwes (George Bell and Sons, 1883), 56.

¹⁹ Fernán Díaz de Toledo, *Instrucción del Relator* (1449), cited in Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 126.

²⁰ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 121.

justified discriminating against conversos regardless of their stated faith²¹. By redefining heresy as an immutable trait, this paved the way to prosecution based on lineage rather than belief.

In June 1449, amidst anti-converso riots, the city of Toledo formalized *limpieza de sangre* by enacting the *Sentencia-Estatuto* into law. This legislation established the first legal precedent for racial exclusion against New Christians. The decree states, “conversos of Jewish lineage, being suspect in the faith... [who] frequently belittle it by Judaizing... shall not be allowed to hold office or benefices public or private.”²² These laws mark the shift of the idea of a baptized Jew being a Christian to being suspect by virtue of lineage. This refined the nature of heresy, moving beyond the Medieval definition of beliefs contrary to theological teachings, to blood status. These statutes foreshadow the coming Inquisition concern not with theology, but ancestry.

These laws prompted an immediate condemnation from Rome, which did not view them as a protection of faith but as a violation of it. In a bull issued in September 1449, Pope Nicholas V specifically rejected the *conversos*’ exclusion from governance, declaring: all Christians “are admitted to all dignities, honors, offices of notaries, depositions of witnesses and all other things,” arguing “all Catholics to be one body in Christ.”²³ Despite the Pope's appeal to unification, blood purity laws began to circulate across all of Spain. This early disregard for the view of the Holy See mirrors the coming struggle between the Church’s influence and the sovereign ambitions of the state.

²¹ Meyerson and Roth, “Conversos, Inquisition, and the Expulsion of the Jews from Spain,” 230.

²² Pero Sarmiento and City Council of Toledo, “Sentencia-Estatuto (1449),” in *Medieval Iberia: Readings from Christian, Muslim, and Jewish Sources*, 2nd ed., trans. Kenneth Baxter Wolf (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2012).

²³ Pope Nicholas V, *Humani generis inimicus* cited in Thomas M. Izbicki, *Juan de Torquemada: Tractate Against the Midianites and Ishmaelites*, 1st ed, with Jorge Ledo, *Heterodoxia Iberica Series*, v. 7 (BRILL, 2023), 189.

The ideological architecture for this shift was codified by preachers like the Franciscan friar Alonso de Espina. Espina authored the influential publication, the *Fortalitium Fidei* (‘Fortress of Faith’, 1460), which describes at length the dangers of the Crypto-Jews and *conversos* . He not only condemns Judaism, but he also cites it as a disease, popularizing the ‘Contagion Theory.’ This radical concept posited that the interaction between Christians and Jews was the root cause of heresy, reframing Judaism not solely as a wrong belief, but as a danger²⁴. Espina argued that if unbaptized Jews remained in Spain, they would inevitably seduce New Christians back to Judaism through social interaction.²⁵ This rhetoric, building upon the ideas of blood purity, laid the groundwork to treat heresy not as an individual sin, but as an infection that required immediate intervention.

Despite these concepts creating apprehension, without a mechanism, they remained toothless. It was not until a marriage, a timely political crisis, and the presentation of concrete evidence that the state could be mobilized. The marriage of King Ferdinand of Aragon and Queen Isabella of Castile in 1469 united the two most powerful kingdoms on the peninsula. The two states remained separate in their laws and borders; however, the union yielded a singular executive authority, consolidated the kingdom's military strength,²⁶ and forged a shared political destiny.

When the monarchs visited Seville in 1477, the center of *converso* hostilities, the Dominican prior Alonso de Hojeda seized the political opportunity. Presenting Queen Isabella with alleged evidence of a ring of ‘Judaizing’ *conversos* ,²⁷ Hojeda successfully validated the ideas

²⁴ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition* , 41.

²⁵ King Ferdinand II of Aragon and Queen Isabella I of Castile, “The Edict of Expulsion of the Jews - 1492 Spain,” trans. Edward Peters, Foundation for the Advancement of Sephardic Studies and Culture, accessed December 3, 2025, <http://www.sephardicstudies.org/decreed.html>.

²⁶ William H. Prescott, *History of the Reign of Ferdinand and Isabella, the Catholic* (1845), 2:132.

²⁷ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition* , 52.

preached by Espina with proof that the conspiracy had weight. In the eyes of the Monarchs, these ‘Crypto-Jews’ were no longer only sinners, but people who posed a direct challenge to the sovereignty of the newly unified kingdoms. Convinced that heresy was a threat to their kingdoms’ stability, the Crown formally sent a petition to Rome to establish a new Inquisition, one that would operate under their control.

II: The Usurpation

There had been attempts to create a medieval inquisition in Castile and Aragon as far back as the early 1200s, but without the support of the state, it was rendered ineffective. While the earlier Papal Inquisition had existed in Aragon since the early 1200s, it had been reduced to a dormant state by the fifteenth century.²⁸ Furthermore, the tribunal lacked royal support and faced resistance from the *Cortes* (parliament), which sought to assert control by prohibiting inquisitorial procedures and torture as violations of local *Fueros* (local laws/charters).²⁹ In many cases, heresy was legislated as a secular matter, which would be dealt with in courts outside of the Church.³⁰ The old model crucially also lacked central authority and regular funding, often leading to the work being unorganized, inefficient, and slow.³¹ For the new Inquisition to be effective, the Crown recognized it would need a completely new institutional structure that was centralized, well-funded, and directly answerable to the monarchy.

The papal bull of 1478 marked a radical departure from ecclesiastical tradition, effectively transferring control of the tribunal from the Holy See to the Spanish Crown. In the petition to

²⁸ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of the Middle Ages*, 245.

²⁹ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain; Vol. 1*, 170.

³⁰ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of the Middle Ages*, 184.

³¹ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain; Vol. 1*, 231.

Rome, the Catholic Monarchs requested the power of appointment for the inquisitorial office. On November 1, 1478, Pope Sixtus IV officially granted the bull *Exigit Sinceras Devotionis Affectus*, which formally established a new Inquisition in Castile and gave the exclusive right to appoint and dismiss inquisitors to the Monarchy.³² Unlike the medieval inquisitorial model, which relied on direct instruction from the Holy See for the power of staffing, Ferdinand and Isabella transformed the inquisitors from independent delegates of the Church to civil servants of the State. This structural change was intentional and decisive; by controlling the powers of appointment, the Inquisition would not be an instrument of the Church, but of royal policy.

However, Ferdinand recognized that without the power of the purse, the authority of appointment could prove futile. To avoid the failures of the earlier Inquisitions of Spain and ensure effectiveness, efficiency, and loyalty, the tribunal required substantial and consistent financing. Inquisitors previously operated like independent agents, reliant on confiscations from heretics and subsidies from local bishops to fund their operation.³³ However, this system was inconsistent. Aragonese Inquisitor Nicolas Eymerich noted a century earlier that when there were no confiscations and bishops failed to provide support, "the good work languished."³⁴ In February 1482, Ferdinand officially legislated "ample salaries" for the officials of the new Inquisition, directly from the royal treasury.³⁵ This was a decisive shift by transforming inquisitors from being primarily self-funded to salaried employees of the state, ensuring their dependence not on Rome or on confiscations, but on the Crown.

³² Sixtus IV, *Exigit Sinceras Devotionis Affectus* cited in Lu Ann Homza, *The Spanish Inquisition, 1478-1614: An Anthology of Sources* (Hackett Publishing Company, Inc, 2006).

³³ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 231.

³⁴ Nicolas Eymerich, *Directorium Inquisitorum*, cited in Lea *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 231.

³⁵ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 231.

The power of this new state machinery became immediately apparent upon its establishment in Seville in 1480. Upon appointing the first two inquisitors, the Monarchy gave a grave warning that any failure in duty would lead to their removal and "forfeiture of all their temporalities, and denationalization in the kingdom."³⁶ This underscored the complete and absolute authority of the Crown over the Inquisition. Driven by this pressure, the tribunal set in motion one of its deadliest periods.

In a short time, reports of indiscriminate confiscations and procedural abuses circulated back to Rome. Pope Sixtus IV, recognizing that he had ceded too much power to the Crown, attempted to reverse course. He strove to regain control in a bull issued on April 18, 1482, lambasting the new inquisition for being "moved not by zeal for the faith and the salvation of souls but by the lust of wealth." He went on to claim that "many true and faithful Christians... have without any legitimate proof been thrust into secular prisons, tortured, and condemned as relapsed heretics."³⁷ The bull mandated bishops' supervision over trials and direct appeals of the accused to Rome. These concessions would have gutted the effectiveness of the Crown's new weapon by conceding power to the Pope.

Refusing to accept the Vatican's attempt to regain control, Ferdinand aggressively defended the Inquisition not as a branch of the Church, but as the exclusive property of the Crown. In a letter issued to Sixtus, Ferdinand dismissed the Pope's moral concerns, accusing him of being paid off by *conversos*, a claim which may not have been completely unfounded.³⁸ Regarding the stipulations imposed by the bull, Ferdinand stated he would "never... let them take effect,"

³⁶ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 160.

³⁷ Pope Sixtus IV, Bull of April 18, 1482 cited in Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 587.

³⁸ Meyerson and Roth, "Conversos, Inquisition, and the Expulsion of the Jews from Spain.," 153; Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 233.

demanding that Sixtus to "revoke any concessions and to entrust the management of the Inquisition to the Crown, effectively threatening a break between Spain and the Vatican. In a revealing statement he insists "inquisitors of heretical wickedness be instituted according to my good pleasure and will in these my kingdoms" answerable to the Monarch.³⁹ Ferdinand's response demonstrated his understanding of the Inquisition as fundamentally an instrument of royal policy and control, rather than an independent ecclesiastical body.

Faced with the potential loss of a powerful ally, Pope Sixtus capitulated. In 1483, he formally retracted his restrictions and submitted to Ferdinand's demands by appointing Tomás de Torquemada as the first Inquisitor General of both kingdoms, thus establishing the unified Spanish Inquisition.⁴⁰ This appointment was the final structural victory for the Crown. Ferdinand established the *Consejo de la Suprema y General Inquisicion* (Council of the Supreme and General Inquisition). This new body was not an ecclesiastical court, but a governmental one directly responsible for the operation of the new tribunal. It sat alongside the Councils of State and Finance, directly answerable to the Crown.⁴¹ By 1483, the Crown had fully consolidated control, transforming the medieval tribunal into an instrument of royal policy under the pretext of safeguarding the faith.

The limits of the tribunal's jurisdiction soon would be tested by the *fueros*, ancient charters that guaranteed the civil liberties of the Aragonese. As Ferdinand attempted to expand the tribunal to cities like Teruel and Zaragoza in 1484, he faced immediate backlash. The chronicler of Aragon, Jerónimo de Zurita noted that the nobility was concerned with the tribunal's procedures, specifically, the confiscation of property from many "leaders and gentry" and the refusal to reveal

³⁹ Ferdinand II of Aragon, Letter to Pope Sixtus IV cited in Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain; Vol. 1*.

⁴⁰ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 59.

⁴¹ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain; Vol. 2*, 290.

"the names of witnesses who testified against them."⁴² These measures were not just extreme in nature; they infringed on the *fueros*, which guaranteed the accused the right to face their accuser⁴³. Citing these violations, city authorities in Teruel wrote directly to the King, protesting the expansion of the tribunal into their city.

Ferdinand dismissed their apprehensions, defended the work of the Inquisition, and refused to compromise, flipping the nobles' argument on its head. In his response, he argued that the intention was not to infringe upon the *fueros*, but to enforce them. He reasoned that "It is not to be imagined that vassals so Catholic as those of Aragon would have demanded, or that kings so Catholic would have granted, *fueros* and liberties adverse to the faith and favorable to heresy."⁴⁴ This response is framed as a rhetorical trap. It implies that any attempt to use local laws to restrict the inquisition was, by definition, an attempt to protect heresy. He also notes that "If there are so few heretics as is now asserted, here should not be such dread of the inquisition."⁴⁵ By framing the defense of the *fueros* as a defense of heresy, Ferdinand effectively nullified the laws.

When faced with further resistance elsewhere in Aragon, Ferdinand demonstrated his complete disregard for the local liberties of his realm. When the authorities of Teruel barred entry to two inquisitors, Ferdinand did not respond with ecclesiastical sanctions, but with military force.⁴⁶ In addition to deploying the Royal army, he imposed martial law, appointing Juan Garcés de Marzilla as governor with absolute power. Marzilla declared bluntly that he would not "allow *fueros* or privileges to stand in the way" of the Inquisition.⁴⁷ This intervention was a turning point:

⁴² Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 59.

⁴³ Ibid.

⁴⁴ King Ferdinand II, Letter to the Deputies of Aragon cited in Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 60.

⁴⁵ Ibid.

⁴⁶ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 60.

⁴⁷ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 249.

by using the royal army to force a 'religious' tribunal upon a reluctant city, the Crown demonstrated that the Inquisition effectively stood above the law, superseding centuries of local charters to function as a complete instrument of central authority.

Section III: Weaponizing Jurisdiction

Despite the Crown's usurpation of control, the Inquisition remained bound to Canon Law, limiting jurisdiction to baptized Christians. However, the tribunal weaponized the "indelible seal" of baptism to entrap the *converso* population. Under strict canon law, baptism was definite, regardless of whether the conversion was sincere, forced, or the result of escaping violence.⁴⁸ The individual became a subject of the Church, permanently bound by its laws. This technicality would mean that for *conversos*, any retention of ancestral custom was no longer a benign cultural remnant, but an actionable crime of heresy.

To identify these "crimes," the tribunal revived and modified the medieval "Edict of Grace." This was a grace period in which people could confess to acts of heresy without facing severe punishment. However, the edict functioned primarily as an intelligence-gathering tool. Read aloud in town squares and Churches, these edicts provided a detailed list of Jewish customs, effectively training the Old Christian's to recognize and denounce neighbors.⁴⁹ As a resident of Sigüenza later testified, many confessed only out of fear that "false testimony would be made against them."⁵⁰ In Toledo alone (1486), over 4,000 individuals confessed, driven by these fears. These confessions served a dual purpose; they not only confirmed the King's suspicion of

⁴⁸ Joseph Pérez, *Brève histoire de l'inquisition en Espagne*, Le cours de l'histoire (Fayard, 2002), 22.

⁴⁹ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of the Middle Ages*, 233.

⁵⁰ Resident of Sigüenza, testimony cited in Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 67.

widespread heresy but also created a vast record of intelligence—names and associates—that would be used to launch future prosecutions.

With this intelligence network in place, the scope of heresy widened beyond theological dogma. The "contagion" was no longer defined by what one believed, but how one lived. The list of forbidden practices that could lead to condemnation included eating *pan cotazo* (unleavened bread),⁵¹ changing sheets and lighting lamps on Friday,⁵² or casting one's eyes down during the elevation of the Host at Mass.⁵³ By accepting such domestic habits as proof of apostasy, the tribunal effectively criminalized the daily life of the converso class, targeting racially coded cultural practices rather than genuine religious dissent.

Perhaps most telling was the tribunal's willingness to prosecute based on decades-old evidence. In a system where the accused was denied the names of the accusers, constructing a defense was virtually impossible. The case of Juan de Chinchilla, a tailor in Ciudad Real, serves as a great illustration of this in practice. He was condemned to the stake based on the testimony of a single witness regarding events that occurred sixteen and twenty years previously. This was despite multiple character witnesses testifying that Chinchilla "appeared to be a practicing Catholic."⁵⁴ His execution exemplifies the reality of this new jurisdiction: with indefinite powers and reliance on rumors, the system was systematically designed for abuse, allowing the tribunal to eliminate any target under the guise of the law.

⁵¹ *Auto de Fe* (Saragossa, February 24, 1486), cited in Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 594.

⁵² *Auto de Fe* (Saragossa, October 21, 1486), cited in Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 599.

⁵³ *Auto de Fe* (Saragossa, August 18, 1487) cited in Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 606.

⁵⁴ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 70.

Section IV: The Target

The most damning indictment of the tribunal's integrity came when the Monarchy themselves were forced to acknowledge the system's corruption. The reliance on anonymous denunciations created a weapon that could be easily abused, as it was in 1448. In a shocking revelation, the Toledo tribunal revealed that a group of Jews had organized a conspiracy to sell fabricated testimony to inquisitors. The scandal was so reprehensible that the Crown was forced to intervene, ordering the false witnesses executed.⁵⁵ The fact that such a conspiracy could exist reveals the broken nature of the system. If even the Monarchs themselves were forced to invalidate the tribunal's findings, the broader implications of the evidence for the entirety of the Inquisition must be viewed with skepticism.

As revealing as these stories are, without examining the overall trends of the Inquisition, they risk being dismissed as merely anecdotal. When the records are examined together, the target of the inquisition becomes undeniable. According to Henry Kamen, "99.3 percent of the accused [in Barcelona] ...between 1488 and 1505, and 91.6 percent... [in] Valencia between 1484 and 1530, were conversos of Jewish origin."⁵⁶ These figures dismantle the idea that the tribunal was a general instrument of religious orthodoxy. If the Inquisition was truly designed to root out heresy, which encompassed blasphemy, superstition, and speculation, then one would expect a more representative proportion encompassing both Old and New Christians. Instead, the accused were almost exclusively of Jewish lineage. The data reveals the unspoken reality: the Inquisition was not an instrument of religious correction, but of racial purging.

⁵⁵ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of Spain*; Vol. 1, 169.

⁵⁶ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 59.

This statistical disparity marks the final transformation of the "heretic" as one who opposes theological doctrine, to a racial characteristic. By nearly exclusively targeting conversos, the Inquisition institutionalized the doctrine of *limpieza de sangre* on a national scale. This shift provided the political justification to strip the converso class of their wealth and status, regardless of their actual religious devotions. In the eyes of the tribunal, a *converso* could never be Christian, because their "heresy" was not in their soul, but in their veins.

Section V: The Culmination

Twelve years into the operation of the Inquisition, the crown was forced to confront a harsh reality: it was insufficient. Since the scope was focused on "solving" the "*converso* problem," the inquisitors argued that if a Jewish population remained in Spain, the conversos would continuously be tempted to Judaize. The tribunal was in a futile cycle, able to trim the branches of heresy but unable to eliminate the roots. It became clear that the machinery of the Inquisition, despite possessing absolute power over the baptized, was ineffective if the source of contagion, the Jews themselves, remained.

This realization culminated in the Alhambra Decree, issued on March 31, 1492, a document that explicitly cites the "contagion theory" as its primary justification. Significantly, the Edict relies neither on Canon Law nor Papal authority; it is a purely royal decree. It argues that "there were some bad Christians who Judaized... the great cause of which was interaction between the Jews and these Christians⁵⁷." Here, the legal guise is transparent: the Jews are expelled not for their own

⁵⁷ King Ferdinand II of Aragon and Queen Isabella I of Castile, "Edict of Expulsion."

crimes, but to sanitize the environment for the *conversos*. The expulsion was a comprehensive measure to ensure the success of the Crown's project of national unity.

The purely political nature of this decision is highlighted by the dramatic reversal of Queen Isabella's policies towards Jews. In 1477, she had written, "All Jews in my realms are mine and are under my protection."⁵⁸ By 1492, she signed their expulsion. This paradox confirms that the Monarchy's actions were never about consistent religious principles. When the Jews' presence apparently threatened the racial and political homogeneity the Crown sought to build through the Inquisition, they were expelled. The Expulsion was the final piece of the puzzle: the ultimate use of state power to enforce the ethnic cleansing that the Inquisition had started.

Conclusion:

Ultimately, the Spanish Inquisition was less a campaign of spiritual purification than a calculated instrument of state power. The tribunal was never a servant of the Church but a weapon of the State. By wresting jurisdiction from the Papacy, the Catholic Monarchs used its mechanisms to target the *converso* population, allowing racial and ethnic prejudice to be enforced under the veneer of religious orthodoxy.

This structural transformation was not accidental, but a calculated response to the sociopolitical threat of the *converso* class. By institutionalizing *limpieza de sangre*, the Inquisition shifted the definition of the enemy from the heretic, a matter of belief, to a matter of blood. The

⁵⁸ Kamen, *The Spanish Inquisition*, 21.

statistical dominance of *converso* prosecutions, coupled with the eventual expulsion of the Jews, confirms that the ultimate goal was not the salvation of souls but the purification of the nation.

The legacy of the Inquisition lies in the political reality. As historian Henry Charles Lea observed broadly, while wise leadership will raise civilization, under the “selfish and depraved, it could become the instrument of minute and all-pervading oppression.”⁵⁹ The tribunal stands as a chilling precedent for the modern era, demonstrating how easily the sanctity of law can be hijacked to serve popular prejudice.

Although the Inquisition would not be formally abolished until 1834, 356 years after the Papal Bull that approved its formation, its impact was immediate and irreversible. The Catholic Monarchs achieved their goal of a unified Spain, but at the cost of destroying the *Convivencia* that had defined the peninsula for centuries. In 1496, Pope Alexander VI, the head of the Church that Ferdinand had battled for control over a decade before, bestowed upon Ferdinand and Isabella the title *Los Reyes Católicos* (the Catholic Monarchs) for their “defense of the faith.”⁶⁰ There is profound irony in this. This title, implying universal spiritual unity, was awarded to the very same Monarchs who led a campaign of expulsion that violated the faith’s most fundamental tenets. In their ambition to unite a nation, Ferdinand and Isabella demonstrated that for the Spanish Crown, the Cross was not a symbol of unity, but of separation.

⁵⁹ Lea, *A History of the Inquisition of the Middle Ages*, 6.

⁶⁰ Prescott, *Ferdinand and Isabella*, 2:312.

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